

Summing Up

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All's well that ends well; still the fine's the crown;

Whate'er the course, the end is the renown.

—WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE

LEARNING FROM LIFETIME STUDIES does not stop until the lives have been fully lived—and not even then, because archives of prospective data are an invitation and an opportunity to go back and ask new questions time and time again, even after the people who so generously provided the answers are gone.

Each time the Study of Adult Development was threatened with extinction—in 1946, in 1954, in 1971, and in 1986—the grant-makers asked, “Hasn’t the Study been milked dry?” There was a time when I thought that after the College men reached sixty-five and retired, there was nothing more to do but watch them die. Yet the Study always survived—to teach, to surprise, and to give. Granting agencies must be selective, it is true, but they must be selective the way foresters are. Longitudinal studies are the redwood forests of psychosocial studies. Fallen branches and felled trees are useful in the short run. Faithfully maintained and imaginatively harvested, the older the forest gets, the more it is worth. But once cut down it can never be restored.

Obviously, the point of the Grant Study’s seventy-five years is not that it gratified the narcissism of a ten-year-old who wanted the most powerful telescope in the world, nor that it helped to resolve the grief of a boy whose father died too young. I am a real part of this Study, but a small one. It is very much worth noting that so many provocative findings have come out of it—findings that could have been discovered by no other means—that it has taken ninety-five different authors to elucidate them.

It is certainly appropriate to assess the cost-to-benefit ratio of a follow-up study that endured for more than seven decades at a cost of twenty million dollars. And in some ways that is easy to do. The bean-counter in me points out that granting agencies have paid only \$10,000 in award, on average, per peer-reviewed—and sometimes highly cited—book or journal article. That’s not an exorbitant cost as these things go. But the Study’s three greatest contributions, which justify its cost and give meaning to the extraordinary generosity, patience, and candor of the men who exposed their entire lives in the interests of science, are less easily subject to financial valuation.

The first contribution is the absoluteness of the Study’s demonstration that adult development continues long after adolescence, that character is not set in plaster, and that people do change. Even a hopeless midlife can blossom into a joyous old age. Such dramatic transformations are invisible to pencil-and-paper explorations or even ten-year studies of adult development. ¹

Second, in all the world literature there is no other study of lifetime alcohol abuse as long and as thorough as this one.

Third, the Study’s identification and charting of involuntary coping mechanisms has given us at once a useful clinical tool, a route to empathy for initially unlikable people, and a powerful predictor of the future. Without this long Study of real lives, the importance of the maturation of defenses would still be out of fashion, dismissed as a relic of failed psychoanalytic metaphysics. In this final chapter I will briefly review each of these three contributions.

DEVELOPMENT IS LIFELONG

Adult development is a lifelong process. To investigate it properly means lifelong study—for which even seventy years is not really quite long enough. Many students of adult development, most brilliantly Warner Schaie in the Seattle Longitudinal Study, have tried to speed up the process by studying several groups of varying ages concurrently over ten or even twenty years. ² This method worked in Schaie’s study of the rise and fall of intelligence, which can be studied in

populations. But it cannot work for the study of personality, which is unique to individuals. The study of old age in particular requires patience and empathy, not the restless intolerance of frightened fifty-year-olds such as I was in 1986. Without persistence, endurance, and restraint, we learn little about the delicate processes of growth that endure even as life is fading.

Piaget's and Spock's delineations of child development changed parenting forever. Erikson's appreciation of adult development as dynamic growth rather than decay was likewise a major paradigm shift. ³ But without empirical evidence to back it up, it gave rise to more theory and speculation than knowledge. The Grant Study has changed that. Four major empirical works have come out of the Study under my name— *Adaptation to Life* (1977), *Wisdom of the Ego* (1993), *Aging Well* (2002), and this final summary volume—which clarify the second half of life a decade at a time. As the men went on maturing, as hypotheses were tested and retested over time, the books have become progressively less theoretical and more evidence-based. Future studies and wiser authors will take us further still. But the optimum (to borrow a concept from Arlie Bock) study of lifetimes will always require a hundred years of toil, generations of dedicated investigators, and stories of real lives supported by statistical verification. As I keep reminding myself, what people say doesn't mean much. It's what they do that predicts the future. It was the facts of people's long-term love relationships, not their belief systems, that showed us what we needed to know first about their capacity to love, and then about their mental health.

The realities of adult development cannot be discerned through speculation, through biography (by definition retrospective), or even through diaries (by definition biased). Yet theorists of adult development have had to depend upon just such sorts of materials, so scarce have alternatives been. The very distinguished Terman and Berkeley longitudinal studies rarely published case studies. Before the Grant Study, accurate individual records of adult development were rare.

Sadly, the bellwether publication in the field, the *Journal of Adult Development*, while rich in theory and informative about given stages of adult development, pays almost no attention to real lives or to maturational changes, which are full of paradox. This can be seen in the quixotic truth that at the same time as the Grant Study was demonstrating incontrovertibly that adult development continues throughout the lifespan, it was offering support for the contradictory view of William James and other nay-sayers of whose work I once made light. Lifetime studies hoist us investigators with the very petards that we delight to deploy against our challengers.

Let me illustrate that apparent contradiction, which lies in the vulnerability of all belief systems. In sitting down to write this book, I believed that it was only the tracking of behavior over time that could predict the future, not inventories or questionnaires or any of psychology's other myriad "instruments." Paul Costa and Robert McCrae believed that because a person's NEO has not changed over thirty years, his character has not changed either. ⁴

I had no problem with the first half of that contention; indeed, we found that among the College men the NEO did not change very much over forty-five years (see Chapter 4). ⁵ I even found, in running the numbers, that the NEO traits of Neuroticism (negatively) and Ex-traversion (positively) were significantly predictive of some Decathlon outcomes. But I did have trouble with the second half—that the lack of change in the NEO meant a lack of change in personality. The NEO traits—uncomfortably like the elegant and empirically derived anthropologic measurements with which this book began—are static. They do not address processes of growth, any more than a masculine body build, which may well endure over a lifetime, predicts the kind of officer its owner will grow to become. The NEO deals with personality as reflected in multiple choice questions, and although I tried, I could not correlate any of its traits with the five mature defenses (altruism, sublimation, humor, suppression, and anticipation) that do change over time, and in their changing exert such an important influence on the outcomes of real lives.

But having hoisted Costa on his own petard—for failing to recognize the difference between static measurements and dynamic processes—I proceeded to hoist myself on mine. It occurred to me that if Extraversion (positively) and Neuroticism (negatively) could predict the Decathlon to a limited degree, it might be interesting to create a theoretical composite value: Extraversion minus Neuroticism. That is, what would happen if I removed from consideration the thwarting effects that Neuroticism had on Decathlon success? What happened was that the Extraversion minus Neuroticism values correlated at least significantly with every Decathlon event for which data was available, rivaling adaptive style and childhood in predictive power. As illustrated in Table 11.1 , Extraversion minus Neuroticism estimated at age twenty-one could predict the Decathlon measured with data gathered forty to sixty years afterward, and it could

predict it as well as adaptive style assessed twenty years later! My ship of fine theories had crashed upon the rocks, but truth was well served.

The moral of this story is that they were right and I was right. My rightness did not preclude theirs; theirs did not preclude mine. My rightness was not complete, and theirs wasn't either, and the whole is greater than the sum of its parts. There's more than one path to the top of a mountain, and there are prizes enough for everyone: Woods, Soldz, Bowlby/Vaillant, Costa/McCrae. But note that it was only in the context of lifelong study that the question of changing adaptive style could even be tested. Context is everything, and lifetime studies provide it most generously.

Table 11.1 Statistical Strength of Association of Alternative Predictors of Flourishing *

* 168 men were included in this table. Only the classes of 1942–1944 were rated for defenses, and some men have been lost to death.

Very Significant = $p < .001$; Significant = $p < .01$; NS = Not Significant.

The Grant and Glueck Studies make clear another important dynamic reality that personality inventories, or even retrospective and cross-sectional studies, cannot: childhood trauma becomes less important with time (even though recovery may take decades), while the good things that happen in childhood endure. A related finding was that environmental conditions that appear very important to outcome in ten-year studies—such as parental social class, loss of a parent, or membership in a multiproblem family—appear much less important over the entire course of a life. Some environmental circumstances, of course, were not tested in the Grant Study and are likely to remain important, such as racism and other forms of societal discrimination. In our admittedly small Inner City sample, however, confined as it was to 456 white urban males, a warm childhood environment appeared to be a far better predictor of future social class and of adult employment (or unemployment) than was either childhood intelligence, parental dependence upon welfare, or the presence of multiple problems within the family. 6 For the Inner City men, the percent of life employed (a behavioral item) was one of the best objective predictors of mental health that the Study possessed, and employment was uncorrelated with social disadvantage. Children of great privilege with personality disorders have greater difficulty with stable employment than the mentally stable uneducated poor.

Another point of interest: it is through lifetime studies that we discover the tools we need for future investigation. The best tool we have for predicting longevity was discovered only through the study of entire lifetimes. Summarizing findings from the Berkeley and Oakland Growth Studies, arguably the greatest study of human development in the world, the distinguished sociologist John Clausen observed that when his subjects were sixty-five to eighty-five years old, the childhood trait of Planful competence and dependability was the most important predictor of future mental and physical well-being. 7 Howard Friedman arrived at the same conclusion in summarizing the longevity of the Terman men; I confirmed his finding seeking predictors of estimated longevity among the Grant Study men with the traits Well integrated and Self-driving. 8 But until the Terman, Berkeley, and Grant Studies reached maturity, the longevity literature had never even considered the importance of what Howard Friedman called Conscientiousness.

As I've described at some length in Chapter 6, the Study has made some important discoveries about marriage: that 57 percent of the Grant Study divorces were associated with alcoholism; that divorce led to future marriages happier than those enjoyed by the couples in the lowest third of sustained marriages; that marriages become happier after seventy. These issues have gone largely unaddressed in the literature on marriage. Time will take care of that. The point I want to make here is that these findings were not perceived even in the Grant Study itself until sixty or seventy years had passed. To understand lives takes a lifetime.

ALCOHOLISM

Much of what we infer retrospectively about our lives is not true. Nowhere is this more evident than in lifetime studies of alcoholism, where the Study of Adult Development has made perhaps its greatest contribution. In 1980 the Study was already the longest study of alcoholism in history, and had been awarded the international Jellinek Prize, a biennial award for alcohol research. 9 If it had stopped there, though, two other important discoveries that were published many years later would never have been made. 10

To disprove the illusion that securely diagnosed alcoholics can return to successful social drinking required that we follow Inner City alcoholics for thirteen more years after they had been rated as returned-to-social-drinkers in 1983. Disaster was only a matter of time, like driving a car without a spare tire. And proofs that are a matter of time take time.

It also took many years to spot alcoholism as an unrecognized confounder in many classic studies of psychosocial effects on physical health. It is often unacknowledged alcoholism that causes precisely those stressors—the bankruptcy, the job loss, the divorce—on which the victim’s poor health is blamed. Not until the men were eighty did the Study discover data showing that alcoholism (entirely unmentioned in prior major studies of marriage and divorce) was by far the most important factor in Grant Study divorces. Prolonged prospective study is a gift that keeps on giving—and surprising.

INVOLUNTARY ADAPTATION

The elucidation of resilience is the third way that the Grant Study has earned its lifetime of support. Its time-lapse photographs of human development illustrate and validate what is perhaps Freud’s greatest discovery—the existence of involuntary coping mechanisms and their profound effects on adult life. 11 Freud’s discovery of defenses was analogous to the discovery of Pluto by his astronomical contemporaries. In the nineteenth century both Pluto and defenses were invisible; they could be appreciated only by the systematic distortions they caused in the otherwise predictable behavior of visible objects. But twentieth-century telescopes allowed Pluto to be seen, and the longitudinal telescope of the Grant Study has permitted the visualization of defenses and their transmutations.

Still, in 2010 a leading textbook of human development referencing 2,500 different investigators and 1,200 topics says not a word about defense mechanisms. 12 Why do involuntary coping styles receive so little attention in the resilience literature now that they are documented as such powerful predictive tools? One general reason is that the latest editions of major textbooks in the field, Kail and Cavanaugh’s *Human Development* and William Crain’s *Theories of Development*, make almost no mention of empirical longitudinal life studies at all. 13 But the more particular answer is that measuring defenses reliably is extremely costly in time, effort, and money; this unpalatable truth tends to obscure the proven validity, and the elegance, of assessing adaptation by defensive style. Paper-and-pencil tests are cheap and easy, and even scientists are sometimes tempted to look for their car keys where the light is good instead of where they dropped them.

Certainly the Grant Study has so far failed to make Freud’s inductive discovery of defenses part of the developmental landscape, and until fMRI evidence becomes available, the study of defenses may retain its scent of unreliability. Human resilience may continue to be conceptualized according to a model very different from my model of involuntary coping, and the baby may continue to be thrown out with the bathwater. It’s not too surprising that Kail and Cavanaugh don’t mention psychoanalysis, although I think that Freud deserves a historical footnote, at least. But the omission of defense mechanisms is another matter altogether. They are real, they are visible, and they are very important. And it is the Grant Study that has documented all three of these assertions.

The good news is that involuntary defense mechanisms are now included in the American Psychiatric Association’s new *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual (DSM-IV)*, and Joshua Shenk’s 2009 cover article for *The Atlantic* on the Grant Study’s investigations of defenses and development won a fascinated national readership. 14 The next few decades of the history of science will decide if the conceptual scheme (that is, the paradigm) of defenses (that is, involuntary coping) is a lasting contribution to resilience and development or not. The jury is still out. Nevertheless, since the study of involuntary coping matters to me a great deal, I will offer a final illustration of its importance to human resilience and development.

THE LIFE OF ERNEST CLOVIS

Artists are people who can share their most private dreams with others through the mature defense of sublimation. Although all the College cohort’s successful academicians were skilled sublimators, like Dylan Bright in Chapter 8 and the elusive Art Miller in Chapter 3, it was Professor Ernest Clovis who was the true artist in this mode of involuntary coping—for a while. What was so striking about Clovis was that he had suffered more personal tragedy than any other man in the Study, yet at midlife he could write, “Perhaps I have not struck any particularly rough spots.” An understanding of defenses enables us not to dismiss such resilience as denial, but to understand and appreciate it as a technique of coping. In Ernest Clovis, the transformation of a healthy childhood coping strategy (narcissistic fantasy) into mature generative sublimation fostered his own resilience and enriched hundreds of grateful students.

Clovis was raised in an austere and religious farming family. He maintained that he had had an enjoyable relationship with both his parents, but he also felt them to be emotionally constricted. He grew up with little physical affection, and his mother revealed to the Study staff that “very early Ernest developed qualities of self-reliance.” He was sent to boarding school at eight years old.

Ernest’s Calvinist family did not tolerate “selfishness,” even the temporary kind that supports separation and individuation, and as a young child of four and five, Ernest took comfort in fantasy. He had an imaginary playmate whose outstanding trait was his egotism, and by his family’s report, this companion was far more real to Ernest for a while than his toys, and maybe even than his brother and sisters. Not only did Perhapsy (that was his name) provide friendship to a geographically isolated little boy, but he also had the marvelous knack of always getting one up on the boy’s dominating father.

As his father recalled it when Ernest entered the Study, “Perhapsy was a most wonderful fellow and could do anything. No matter what we did, especially something out of the ordinary, Perhapsy always did us one better. Once we were taking a train, and while we were waiting for it to leave, Ernest saw other trains moving about the yards. Perhapsy was ‘in the big train over there,’ or he was ‘riding on top of the engine’ or some such courageous stunt. He could climb the highest buildings and mountains in the world, etc., etc. He never took a back seat for anybody.”

But as Ernest grew up, real games took the place of fantasy. “One of us asked him,” his father went on, “when we noticed he was no longer talking about his ‘friend,’ what had become of him. The answer was, ‘Perhapsy is dead.’ ” Ernest was finding fresh ways to bring pleasure to a cerebral life. He learned to beat his father in tennis, and through this sublimated form of aggression they became close. In college, many of the inhibited scholarship boys like Peter Penn rationalized their lack of dates by pleading lack of money. But the equally impecunious Clovis was very successful with the opposite sex. He entertained his companions by taking them to art museums, which were free. Sublimation took the place of money as a gateway to romance.

In college, Clovis impressed Study observers as showing very little emotional color. Some men with childhoods similar to his grew up into emotionally frozen adults, like the lawyer Eben Frost from Chapter 6. Some chose work in the physical sciences, and led rigid lives devoid of observable pleasure. Not so with Clovis. He became a first-rate squash player, a distinguished medievalist, and a good father. After fifteen years of marriage, he and his second wife agreed that they still enjoyed “a very satisfactory” sex life.

During World War II, Clovis fought with Patton’s army through France, and afterward he felt an emotional pull to the French and their culture. Several of his classmates, guilty over their participation in so much destruction overseas, got involved in tangible (and ambivalent) postwar efforts to rebuild Japan and Germany. But Clovis became a scholar of the France that once had been. He plowed through medieval manuscripts; he mastered archaic dialects; he reconstructed an imaginary world that was little more tangible than Perhapsy. But he enjoyed it, and in his enjoyment he managed to connect his fantasy with the real world. From the flintstone of his intellect he struck sparks of marketable excitement, and in this Clovis illustrates a skill critical to the creative process. There is no one lonelier than the artist whose work speaks to no one, and no life less appreciated than that of the scholar who, like Peter Penn, cannot make his ideas comprehensible to the world.

Clovis, in contrast, received the most prestigious scholarships for his graduate work, the warmest accolades of his instructors, and offers of tenure from great universities. He could say, “I have developed a sense of mission that I may contribute to this country a better appreciation of France’s social and political values—not just of her literary and historical contributions.” As a teacher, an author, and a scholar his career was an unqualified success.

His home life was not so smooth. His first wife was stricken with an encephalitis that distorted her personality and rendered her permanently bedridden and irrational. The marriage became progressively and mutually more painful. Neither of his parents had ever shown emotion, and Clovis too had learned early to keep his feelings private. Stoically, he wrote to the Study of the “minor frustration caused by my wife’s encephalitis . . . to discuss it further with my parents would only make them unhappy. . . . I sometimes feel desire to discuss these problems with some of my wife’s women friends, but I have never done this because it would seem like complaining.” He did, however, form close substitute relationships with women. After many years he also finally did obtain a divorce, although he felt profoundly guilty about it, and eventually remarried happily.

I first met Clovis in 1969 in the stacks of Yale's Sterling Library. He had a cramped, almost monastic cubicle filled with old books and musty manuscripts, but it was enlivened by a bright contemporary print. Clovis himself was a pleasant, good-looking forty-seven-year-old man. His somber gray suit was unexpectedly brightened by a flamboyant orange tie. He often looked away as he talked to me, and at first I experienced him as cold. But I soon realized that this was more self-discipline than emotional rigidity, and that he was a very private and self-contained individual whose emotional fires, though banked, gave off both light and warmth. The way he talked often moved me deeply. I learned that talking about people depressed him, but that the discussion of his work, French drama, would bring a smile to his face.

When Clovis told me of his father's death four years previously, his eyes filled with tears. He hastened to assure me, "At the time of my father's death, I had to suppress my feelings." When he talked of the tragedy of his first wife's illness, he became distant, acutely anxious, and distressed. Talking of his happier second marriage, he became warmer and maintained eye contact.

Clovis told me that before his first wife got sick, modern English-American theater had been a shared hobby for the two of them. Once she could no longer go to plays with him, he became passionately interested in early and arcane French dramatists. On the verge of a divorce that his conscience could not countenance, he chose to translate from medieval French "the romantic tragedy of the hopeless love of a married man and a prostitute, both of whom chose to commit suicide rather than to be false to their love." This self-denying professor, who in the light of day could not permit himself tears, found himself weeping alone in darkened French theaters at plays that were of only historical importance to most English-speaking people. "I cry along with the old ladies," he confessed, "and feel thrilled by the experience." But Clovis was no schizoid eccentric; he did not keep his source of comfort secret. At Yale he brought the early French theater vividly to the awareness of his students.

In 1972 Clovis's daughter was diagnosed with lupus erythematosus, a poorly understood disease that causes arthritis, irreversible kidney damage, and episodic emotional instability. He was affectively aware of his daughter's peril and the awful years of his first wife's illness were again before him. But he continued to embrace the one area of his life where he could always maintain control. He wrote that he felt "enthusiastic" about the future because of the scholarly writing on French drama that he had planned. He added, "The language of the material you read has an emotional, aesthetic satisfaction."

Had he been unable to communicate his secret world of medieval France to others, he might have become deeply depressed. But as long as he could empathically communicate the scholarship in which he sublimated his feelings, he could retain an almost palpable animal vigor and joie de vivre.

When I saw Clovis again in 1996, he was seventy-five, still happily married to his second wife, and close to his four children. And he had become—in a sense—a Guardian. But as Eriksonian made clear from the beginning, every developmental accomplishment has a shadow side. The shadow of Intimacy is Isolation; the shadow of Generativity is Stagnation. The shadow of Guardianship, which I have called Hoarding, is preservation for its own sake, and Clovis had gotten trapped there.

Not all traditions merit preservation, and very few merit preservation at any cost. The ones that are worthy have value beyond tradition itself. In Polonius, Shakespeare gives us a classic example of elderly rigidity, which is the potential vice of all grandparents.

Clovis still wanted to create, to research, to write. But alas, there was no time. He was now the curator of a great library collection; he was editing a history of medieval France; he was editing his wife's papers; he was certainly preserving the past for the future. But in these efforts he had exiled himself from the medieval world where his imagination could run free. To continue his own work, he felt, would be "self-interest and selfishness." When I asked him if he wouldn't rather write about early French theater than be a library curator, he lightened up briefly. Perhaps lived on inside him. But he caught himself, and became again a "responsible" professor emeritus and grandfather.

Unlike the other Guardians we've seen in these pages, he had left his rich inner life behind him in the service of what felt to him like the obligations of late middle age. I found myself thinking of the eighty-year-old Robert Sears, a "Termite" (as the gifted Terman children called themselves) and a brilliant and creative professor of psychology. I remember watching him in the Terman Study archive, unpaid, sorting the old IBM punch cards—a thankless task if there

ever was one—so that young whippersnappers like me could enjoy an orderly universe in which to make our reputations. He was cultivating his garden—as I cultivate mine in the Grant Study, long after retirement—and he did it with joy, not out of obligation.

Sublimation is a way of negotiating with the superego, of getting around guilt, of finding pleasure if not in the forbidden garden, then at least in the garden next door. It served Clovis very well for a long time, but his Calvinist conscience eventually got its own back. Clovis had never freed himself from his guilt over having divorced his first wife, and as new obligations piled up—the library, the papers, the editing—they fed his superego until it became strong enough to shut the door to his passionate medieval world. Like Newman, who was always part mystic and part engineer, Clovis was always part ascetic and part troubadour. In his case, the ascetic eventually won out. At least for the time being, Perhapsy was dead once more. People change; people don't.

Professors Clovis and Bright, however good they were at sublimation, were not examples of ideal flourishing any more than Beethoven was. Nor were they among the best outcomes in the Study. In fact, sublimation was only slightly more correlated with the success in the Decathlon of Flourishing than the neurotic defenses. Sublimation does not cure all ills. Its superiority lies in the fact that, unlike the neurotic defenses, it transforms agony into real pleasure—but a pleasure, unlike the more narcissistic defenses, that conforms to the needs of others. Beethoven's need to create magic in music was as involuntary as the clotting of his blood, but just as critical to his resilient survival. To replace valid dynamic defenses that can and do change with maturity in favor of the reliable Big Five would be as foolish as ignoring the girlfriends and best mates of the College sophomores and studying only their body build—a mistake that the Grant Study made once and will not encourage others to make again. Its demonstration that intangible coping styles are relevant to modern social science made the Grant Study worth every penny spent on it, and worth the five years of my life that I have continued to devote to it—like Professor Sears—with no compensation at all.

IF WISHES WERE HORSES. . .

I am often asked how I would design a lifetime study if I had the opportunity to build one from scratch, instead of just walking into the Grant Study as I did and watching it grow. Let me close this history with my answer.

First, I would ask for an endowment to be run like an annuity, to last one hundred years. That would ensure that minimal continuity could be maintained even during lean years.

Second, in selecting my cohort I would not try for inclusive diversity, but I would include children of both sexes from no more than two contrasting ethnic groups. Sociology requires a large representative sample; biology needs small homogeneous samples. Historical change alters the rules of sociology; the rules of biology and ethology are more constant. In designing my ideal study I remain a biologist and an ethologist. And I would focus on blue-collar children, because (despite the reasoning of the early planners) the Inner City men provided even more surprises than the College men did.

Third, along with DNA and social security numbers for all the members of my cohort, I would collect the names, birth dates, and addresses of five relatives under sixty who do not live with them. The names and addresses of research subjects change with frustrating regularity, and this would spare us the huge investment in detective work that lost subjects demand.

Fourth, I would concentrate on finding and using the best measures available to assess the positive emotions (joy, compassion, trust, hope, and their like), and attachment.

Fifth, I would assess involuntary coping through a two-hour videotaped couples interview every twenty years in preference to the excerpted vignettes that I used. That way real-time rater reliability could be obtained, and a major source of bias (the excerpting) removed.

Sixth, consistent with safe x-ray exposure limits, I would collect neuroimaging data every five years. Like the men who started the Grant Study, I am not quite sure what I would be looking for—the brain changes that accompany the evolution of twenty-year-old narcissism into seventy-year-old empathy?—but the ambitious kids reviewing the data in 2050 certainly would be.

Finally, I would keep data collection simple enough so that after fifty years investigators would not be drowning in their own accumulations. The Grant Study was already struggling with this intrinsic problem of longitudinal studies all the way back in 1941, and that was only three years in! I deliberately kept data collection simple, and I take some credit for the long-term survival of the Study of Adult Development because of it. I would keep the Study cohort small enough that every member would remain a person to the Study, and not just a collection of numbers. Every member could maintain a warm alliance with the Study staff, and errors in data would be noticed. And yes, I would collect pencil-and-paper tests—belief systems need to be tested empirically.

CONCLUSION

At ten years old I entertained a Perhapsy-like wish for the greatest telescope in the world. When I was an assistant professor at Tufts Medical School and assumed responsibility for the Grant and Glueck Studies, I believed I had found it—the device that would let me see entire lifetimes at a single glance. In 1969, begging for money as usual, I paraphrased Archimedes to the Commissioner of Mental Health: “Give me the salary for a single research assistant, and I will move the world.” He very graciously told me that he could not do that. But the Grant Foundation did, and I was off and running.

I have spent forty years peering through that telescope, and it has shown me world after world that I never dreamed of. Over those years I’ve developed convictions, and (I pride myself on this, too) exposed them to empirical scrutiny. Three big ones have stood the test of time, if not perfectly. One was that a warm childhood was a most important predictive factor and that a bad childhood was not. Another was the assertion that I made to *The Atlantic*, that the most important contributor to joy and success in adult life is love (or, in theoretical terms, attachment). My third great conviction was the identification of the involuntary adaptive “mechanisms of defense” as the second greatest contributor. Forty years of study have convinced me that in this I was right; mature defenses remain the sine qua non of warm relationships. Alas, however, they do not appear to be essential for sustained good health and successful physical aging—yet another favorite hypothesis washed up as I followed the men into old age.

This extraordinary telescope has brought great joy and meaning to my life. It allowed me to embark upon a quest that had haunted me from childhood, exploring questions that matter to me both personally and scientifically. It has provided me with wonderful companions on the way—not only my many colleagues over all these years, but also the Study members themselves. And I become more and more aware that the Study, and the work we’ve done with it, has encouraged other people to think about their own lives and the lives of others. Not statistically, perhaps, but with a little more curiosity and a little more interest and a little more kindness. And how can that hurt?

APPENDIXES

NOTES

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